

Fuji Finepix M603

Hard to hold, hurts to pay

The M603, with its silver finished plastic body, looks more like a tiffin box than a camera! The most noticeable difference is the absence of an optical viewfinder, replaced by a large 2.5-inch LCD. Due to the new upright design, the shutter release and the zoom controls are placed on the sides of the camera, which takes a toll on usability. Fuji has provided a grip handle that screws into the tripod mount, stabilising the camera when the controls are used.

The M603 has a 3.1 mega pixel CCD, a 3X optical zoom and a 4.4X digital zoom. Shutter speeds range from 1/4 of a second, to 1/2000 of a second with 64 zone TTL metering, using which one can take photographs even in low light conditions. Seven



white balance modes have been provided. Apart from the auto mode, the camera has four flash modes. The ISO speed varies from a minimum of 160 to 1600, which is excellent, in case you want to increase the gain of the CCD for night shoots. The M603 has provisions to read both, xD memory cards and Compact Flash Type II cards, and is also microdrive compatible, thus providing you enough memory options to choose from.

In the image test, the average colour deviation was 3 per cent for red, and a little less than 10 per cent for green and blue. The images were sufficiently bright with no dark corners. In the Specular effects and gradation test, the images were strictly average.

The M603 was able to pick out most details, but fared poorly at colour reproduction—it lost all its points due to a dull reproduction in the RGB target test. The F601 was comparatively better than the M603 in this respect. While testing for zoom, and in the actual person test, it showed a decent performance.

The camera is priced at Rs 46,500, which does not justify its so-so performance at all. Chip in a bit more, and you get the IXus 400, which fares much better.

- + Support higher resolutions and various memory formats
 - Shoddy ergonomics
- Price: Rs 46,500

Fuji Finepix M603		C+
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Ergonomics	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Fuji Finepix S304

Can't afford to miss

The S304 looks like a SLR with its huge 6X optical zoom lens, and the new xD memory card. The plastic body has a silver finish, and dark-grey rubber grips are thrown around to produce a stark contrast. The back sports a big viewfinder, with the anti-reflective LCD screen. The buttons are placed within your thumb's reach. The ones pertaining to the LCD are placed just above it.

Ergonomically, the S304 was the best camera in the entire test—the grip on the right side is perfect, and even the batteries are placed cleverly to balance out the weight of the lenses.

The camera features an effective CCD count of 3.2 megapixels, and 6X optical zoom and a 3.2X digital zoom. The shutter speed varies from 3 seconds to 1/2000th of a second. There are five different white balance settings, apart from the auto mode. The only gripe that we found was the 16 MB xD memory card—the camera deserves at least 32 MB.

In the image test, the S304 had no problems detecting red, with an average deviation of just over 3 per cent. Unfortunately, the average deviation with green and blue, was more than 20 per cent. Overall, the image looked a bit dull and saturated. In the specular effect and gradation effect test, nothing quite beats the S304. It lost some critical points while picking up finer details. In the RGB target test, the S304 responded well to red and blue, but failed to pick up green very well. In the zoom test and the actual person test, the scores were average.

At Rs 35,000, it is an absolute must for those looking for a high-end camera on a shoestring budget. It also comes with frills such as a conversion lens adapter. Good features, great performance and most importantly, a terrific price makes it an absolute winner.



"Is very fast. Does not have the 2-3 seconds wait to fire. Image quality is excellent too. Has a good grip, a digital viewer and is equipped with a hood to block flare. At 40,000 it may sound expensive but makes up on quality. Will get lots of buyers if priced at about 35-38,000. I could be one."

—Sherwin Crasto

- + Excellent ergonomics, good features and value for money
 - Quite bulky
- Price: Rs 35,000

Fuji Finepix S304		B
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Ergonomics	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Mr. Santa Claus

Think beyond Red and White.

Microsoft